

Online Experiments for Language Scientists, 2026-2027, **Postgraduate (LASC11167)** Assignment brief

[Also see below for information on optional formative assignment, due 12th November]

Sole assessment: coding project plus report, due 10th December, worth 100% of course mark

The assessment has two parts:

1. A functioning experiment running on jspsychlearning.ppls.ed.ac.uk
2. A report explaining the motivation behind that experiment: i.e. the research question it is intended to answer (including briefly reviewing relevant literature and justifying that research question in terms of broader questions in the field), explanation/justification for any complex or questionable design decisions you took in designing the experiment (there's no need to justify low-level stuff), an appraisal of weakness of your experiment or possible ways it could be improved/extended. **The maximum length for the report is 1000 words.**

The experiment has to be relevant to using online experimental methods to study language or language-relevant phenomena, but beyond that there are no constraints on what you tackle - please have a short conversation with me (Kenny) if you are at all unsure about what you have in mind is appropriate.

We will assess these final projects based on two components: the technical ambition and implementation of the experiment, and the quality of the accompanying report and explanation. For technical ambition / implementation we will give high marks to challenging coding problems (e.g. going beyond the template experiments we provide for practicals), and experiments that work well and look good. For the report we will give high marks to projects that are well motivated by the literature, answer interesting well-explained research questions, and demonstrate interesting critical insights on your own work (e.g. interesting thoughts on design decisions or methodological weaknesses, even if you weren't able to resolve those in the code).

You can choose how you weight your effort across these two components, e.g. if you tackle a demanding coding project we will be satisfied with a lower-effort report (e.g. with a less thorough literature review or less extensive evaluative remarks); if you are less ambitious on the technical side (e.g. largely re-using code we provide and 'just' plugging in different stimuli, trial lists etc) then we would expect a more ambitious report (e.g. with a more careful and detailed literature review situating your work in the literature in a thoughtful way). Again, please have a short conversation with Kenny if you want some guidance on how you should balance up these two components or how you should make sure you are doing something at the appropriate level of ambition.

Important points on providing a working URL for your experiment:

- Please include the URL of your experiment (hosted on the jspsychlearning server) near the top of your report so we can access it. **This will be of the form <https://jspsychlearning.ppls.ed.ac.uk/~UUN/path>** where UUN is your student number (e.g. s24...) and path is the path to your experiment's html file. If you include a link to the local files on your computer rather than a version of the experiment on the jspsychlearning server, we won't be able to access your code and you will fail. If you include the wrong URL (e.g. using the "Open URL" option in cyberduck, which generates a URL with an error in it) then we may have difficulty accessing your experiment, and you may fail. We show you how to put experiments on the server and access them via a URL in the labs, so make sure you take understand this!
- We will run through everyone's experiment, so if there is anything we need to know (e.g. if you have to give us a password to progress past a certain stage, if we need to run in two browsers simultaneously, etc) please include this info at the top of your report.

Additional notes:

- This assignment is intentionally open-ended - I want everyone to engage with both aspects of the course (engaging with the literature, building actual web experiments), but I also want to be flexible enough to allow you to focus on what you are most interested in and/or what you feel will best illustrate your engagement with the course, and to allow flexibility in terms of how technically challenging your project has to be - not everyone is going to become a coding whizz in 1 semester, you are all starting from different levels of coding experience, but the intention is that this assignment is flexible enough to allow everyone to get a good mark.
- Because it's open-ended, we are relying on you to not overcommit on this one assignment - while nothing in the format prevents you from handing in a challenging programming exercise *and* a publication-quality report, this is not necessary to get a good mark and you will eventually face diminishing returns.
- It's up to you whether you want to build an experiment with a novel element (e.g. a tweak to an existing experiment, or something entirely new) or one which closely replicates an existing study in the literature. Either is fine, but if you are focussing on replicating an existing experiment then you need to justify why that replication is necessary in your report (e.g. do you have reasons to be sceptical about the original result, is it particularly important that its robustness is checked, does going online allow you to access some theoretically-important new population, ...).

Optional formative assessment: annotated bibliography, due 12th November, worth 0% of course mark

If you choose to, you can also submit an annotated bibliography by 12th November – this is identical to Assessment 1 for the undergraduate students, please consult their assignment brief for details of the format. This gives you the option to get some feedback (but not a mark!) on your interpretation of some papers you have been using, which might help you in preparing for the assessed assignment. If you submit this optional assessment, I will provide feedback.

Policy in the use of generative AI

The formal policy for this course is as follows: Academic integrity is an underlying principle of research and academic practice. All submitted work is expected to be your own. AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, the Edinburgh Language Model) should not be used to generate written text or code for your assignments for this course. However, you are allowed to use these tools to identify ideas, key themes, and plan your assessments, and to help you figure out how to write code yourself. You may also use it to improve the clarity of your writing. If you use AI software, you must acknowledge its use in your submission, using the cover sheet provided (this is linked from the course github page alongside the assignment brief).

Some additional remarks. Having used ChatGPT and Claude myself (including for coding and experimenting with its responses to assessments like these), I'd add the following observations: 1) the text it produces is obviously incredibly impressive for a machine, but for an undergrad or Masters essay it can be superficial may lack the critical engagement and evidence of both wide and specialized reading we are looking for (which is slightly ironic since it's certainly read very widely!); 2) its answers sometimes contains interesting or unexpected links that could be worth pursuing, but it can be prone to fantasizing evidence that does not exist; 3) it can do badly with references, and frequently produces references to papers which either do not exist or which do not contain content relevant to the claim they are being cited to support. This will be extremely obvious to anyone who knows the literature who reads your essay; 4) it's great at generating code, but it's very easy for me to tell if an experiment has been generated this way; I can often tell just by looking at the experiment in my web browser, I can definitely tell if I look at the underlying code. This means that relying on generative AI to build your final experiment is a bad idea.